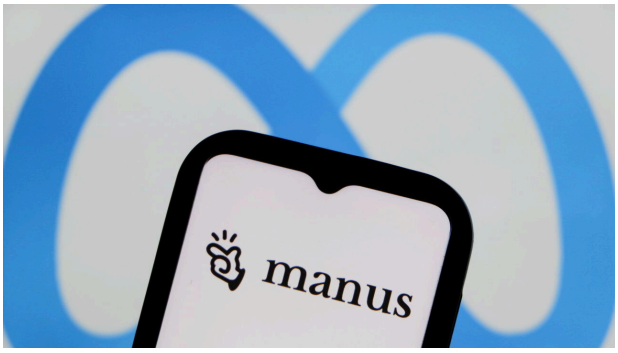
The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Reuters

China blocked **Meta's** $2bn acquisition of Manus, an artificial-intelligence startup, ordering both firms to cancel the transaction. The social-media giant had tried to buy the Chinese company as part of its strategy to invest heavily in AI. Although initially welcomed as a victory for China's AI sector, the deal drew scrutiny from the government, which feared losing its tech to American ownership.

Cole Tomas Allen, the gunman arrested at the **White House Correspondents' Association** dinner on Saturday, was charged with attempting to assassinate Donald Trump, as well as two firearms offences. The 31-year-old reportedly wrote a manifesto in which he promised to target Trump administration officials, "prioritised from highest-ranking to lowest". Mr Trump—unnamed, but the likely target of the foiled attack—earlier called the suspect "anti-Christian".

The White House said Mr Trump had discussed a new proposal to end the war in Iran with his national security team. **Iran's** plan would prioritise a ceasefire and reopen the Strait of Hormuz but delay talks on its nuclear programme. **Marco Rubio**, America's secretary of state, called it "unacceptable". Earlier Abbas Araghchi,

Iran's foreign minister, met Vladimir Putin in Russia. The Russian president praised Iran for fighting "heroically" against America.

Pirates seized a cargo ship off the coast of **Somalia**—the fourth such attack in less than a week. Britain's maritime authorities warned of increasing danger to vessels in Somalia's coastal waters and raised the threat level in the area to "substantial". After a decline in piracy in the 2010s, attacks have recently become more prevalent in the region.

Microsoft will no longer have exclusive rights to sell **OpenAI's** products. Under the terms of a revised deal, the software giant will be offered the ChatGPT developer's models first, but they will then be made available to rival cloud providers including Amazon and Google. Microsoft will no longer pay OpenAI a share of the revenue it makes from selling the AI lab's services on the cloud.

Shell, an international oil major, announced that it will buy **ARC Resources**, a Canadian shale-producer, for $13.6bn. The acquisition will add 370,000 barrels of oil equivalent per day to Shell's output—increasing it by more than 10%. Analysts had previously warned that the company would soon face a production shortage without an acquisition or discovery as output at many of their existing fields was declining.

Wizz Air's boss, József Váradi, accused Gulf airlines of continuing to operate flights during the Iran war because of government pressure rather than independent safety assessments. He said carriers such as Flydubai did not "observe safety and security" and that he would not fly them himself. The unusually blunt attack comes as European airlines are cutting routes to the Gulf.

Figure of the day: $150,000, the auction price of a four-foot-tall Labubu doll, a toy at the centre of a strange speculative bubble. Read the full story.

Photograph: AFP

Elon Musk and Sam Altman battle in court

A trial worthy of Hollywood is about to begin in California. The world's richest man, Elon Musk, will face off against Sam Altman, boss of the world's most famous AI company. Mr Musk helped set up OpenAI, the firm behind ChatGPT, as a non-profit venture in 2015, but departed in 2018. He argues that Mr Altman (and others) went against that founding principle by shifting to a profit-driven structure. He wants OpenAI and Microsoft, one of its backers, to pay more than $134bn in damages—to go to OpenAI's charitable arm, he says—and remove Mr Altman and Greg Brockman, another co-founder. OpenAI claims this is a baseless attempt by a weaker rival (Mr Musk owns xAI as part of SpaceX, his rocket company) to undermine the industry front-runner.

Both billionaires are expected to testify. A verdict may take weeks. Betting markets don't much fancy Mr Musk's chances. The jury, selected on Monday, can expect some drama with their duty.

Photograph: U.S. Central Command

Stasis in the Strait

Bahrain, currently president of the UN Security Council, will chair a meeting on maritime security on Monday. The issue is crucial for both the kingdom and its neighbours in the Gulf, but the meeting will only highlight their powerlessness. The Strait of Hormuz is still blockaded by both America and Iran. On average four ships make it through each day (down from around 125 normally). Gulf states want allies to send warships as escorts. That looks unlikely before the war ends.

And a conclusion does not seem imminent. Abbas Araghchi, the Iranian foreign minister, has spent recent days in Pakistan, which has been trying to mediate a deal, but has refused to meet the Americans. The American delegation hasn't turned up at all—the country's diplomats say that they remain unsatisfied with Mr Araghchi's latest proposal for ending the war. The coming days may bring a fresh round of talks. Until then, the standoff continues.

Photograph: Getty Images

An awkward royal visit

The ideal time for a state visit is not shortly after a possible assassination attempt on the host. But even before a gunman stormed the White House correspondents' dinner on Saturday, King Charles III's trip to America, which began on Monday, had diplomats on edge. The visit, ostensibly for the 250th anniversary of American independence, has become a mission to save the "special relationship".

Donald Trump resents British objections to his foreign forays, particularly in Iran. Meanwhile, Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, is "fed up" with the economic impact of the president's actions. And polling suggests the American and British publics are souring on each other's countries, too. Mr Trump is a fan of Britain's royal family: he described his stay at Windsor Castle with King Charles in September as "one of the highest honours" of his life. But pomp and pageantry can go only so far in healing a rift.

Photograph: Getty Images

South Africa’s precarious progress

Monday is “Freedom Day”, when South Africans celebrate the anniversary of the first elections in which all races could vote in 1994. Much has improved in the 32 years since. The country now has a basic welfare state and a larger black middle class. More South Africans socialise across racial lines; two-thirds say they would support the best person for president, regardless of race. The economy—moribund for at least a decade—has recently shown signs of life, partly because of belated reforms to state-owned enterprises such as Eskom, the utility company.

But war in the Gulf has slowed that momentum; South Africa’s reliance on imported fuel makes it vulnerable to rising prices. Though somewhat tempered by a coalition government since 2024, the ruling African National Congress party is still plagued by corruption and incompetence. On April 23rd the president suspended the head of police, the latest powerful figure embroiled in alleged graft. South Africa has come far; it has much further to go.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which character is the main archenemy of the Fantastic Four, in both the comic book and film series?

The beginning is always today.

Mary Wollstonecraft